



Impressive start: On his 10K debut at the World 10K Bengaluru 2025, Sawan clocked an impressive 29:45, announcing himself over the distance with authority. SUDHAKARAJAIN

done well in the 5,000m, I thought I should stick to that distance,” Sawan said. He continued to perform well in the 5,000m and 10,000m, winning gold in the latter with a personal best at last year’s National Games and later at the Federation Cup. But his coaches continued to nudge him towards the marathon.

“Last year, Scott Simmons (who had previously coached Commonwealth Games medallist Avinash Sable and currently coaches Gulveer Singh, Indian national record holder in the 5000m and 10000m) suggested I try the marathon.

“He told me he was confident I would break the national record as well. I thought it might be a good chance to qualify for the Asian Games, so I decided to make the move,” Sawan said.

Gradual shift

The transition came with setbacks. Two months into marathon preparation, Sawan, who trains under Markose as part of the Reliance Foundation Athletics programme, suffered a fall during a run.

“I was supposed to make my marathon debut in October last year, but because of the fall, I had to give up that plan,” he recalled.

This season, at the Rotterdam Marathon, the goal was to break the national record. Several senior runners felt the plan was too ambitious, but Sawan, who had first been told of his potential by Simmons even before he started training for the marathon, remained convinced.

“Even before I switched to the marathon, I would wonder why the national record was 2:12:00 when people in the world were running much faster. I wondered why the national camp athletes were running 2:13:00 and 2:14:00. My

understanding is that because the national record has stood for so long, a lot of runners developed the mindset that we can’t train to run that fast. Many older runners said this to me. They also told me that it wasn’t so easy to shift from the 10000m to the marathon so quickly and that I would really hit a wall at 35 km into the race. But I didn’t think this time was that difficult. I also think that for a long time, Indian runners were training in old-fashioned ways. The priority was avoiding injury rather than pushing themselves,” he said.

With training methods improving in recent years, several runners have come close to Shivnath’s record. Sawan’s Army teammate Gopi Thonakal ran 2:12:23 at the Valencia Marathon last year, while Kartik Karkera clocked 2:13:10 at the New Delhi Marathon earlier this year. While they came close, it was Sawan who finally broke through in Rotterdam. Despite his dramatic finish, both Sawan and his coaches